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California lawmakers might ban public schools from serving food with artificial dyes

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California legislators may decide on a bill this week that would ban public schools from offering foods that contain six synthetic dyes as well as titanium dioxide.

If passed, the bill would outlaw schools from serving drinks, foods and snacks made with blue No. 1, blue No. 2, green No. 3, red No. 40, yellow No. 5 and yellow No. 6.

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, the legislator behind the bill, claims the additives have been linked to health harms in children, including damaging immune systems, issues with neurobehavior and hyperactivity and causing cancer in some cases, pointing to the findings of a 2021 research report published by the California Environmental Protection Agency.

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Gabriel noted in a press release from earlier this year about the bill that titanium dioxide was banned for use in foods by the European Union in 2022 and the group requires foods containing specific dyes to have warning labels about potential harm to children.

"California has a responsibility to protect our students from chemicals that harm children and that can interfere with their ability to learn," said Gabriel.

Despite the concerns, the Food and Drug Administration maintains that the additives approved for use in food, including dyes, meet its safety standards.

Some school districts in California have already banned foods with artificial colors and preservatives, and a spokesperson for the Association of California School Administrators told The Los Angeles Times in March there aren't many schools that sell the snacks and candy targeted in the ban.

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